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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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HEIDI LEVINE FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

The scene at Tel Aviv's Hostages Square on Saturday as live television footage shows the gaunt, pale conditions of three hostages.

Netanyahu decries 'shocking' images

Dazed and malnourished Israeli hostages are paraded in public by Hamas before their release

BY SUSANNAH GEORGE,
ALON ROM,
HEIDI LEVINE
AND MIKHAIL KLIMENTOV

Three Israeli hostages appeared pale and gaunt as they were paraded by Hamas in front of crowds and cameras in Gaza before their release Saturday, a scene Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu described as "shocking."

Ohad Ben Ami, Or Levy and Eli Sharabi, Israeli men aged from 34 to 56, were escorted to a stage and prodded to wave and address crowds in Gaza's Deir al-Balah neighborhood as Hamas fighters and on-lookers cheered. They were then trans-

ferred to representatives of the International Committee of the Red Cross and taken to Israel.

The men, who had been held captive in Gaza for more than 16 months, were exchanged for 183 Palestinian prisoners in the fifth round of releases under the current ceasefire between Israel and Hamas.

Their conditions shocked the Israelis who gathered in Tel Aviv's Hostages Square to watch a broadcast of the exchange. "This is what a crime against humanity looks like!" Israeli President Isaac Herzog said in a statement. He called the event at which Hamas presented the men "a cynical and cruel spectacle."

Netanyahu vowed "the shocking scenes

we witnessed today will not be ignored," his office said. Later, he reiterated: "We will eliminate Hamas and bring our hostages home."

Ben Ami, Levy and Sharabi were abducted by Hamas fighters on Oct. 7, 2023, when militants stormed Israeli communities, killed 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and took 250 more as hostages. Ben Ami and Sharabi were residents of Kibbutz Beer. Levy was abducted from the Nova music festival.

Their conditions contrasted starkly with those of the mostly female hostages released in previous exchanges during the first phase of the ceasefire deal. Those

SEE HOSTAGES ON A22

In chaotic blitz, Musk's core goals come into focus

DIMINISH GOVERNMENT AND AMASS DATA

His AI tools hunt for opportunities to replace humans

BY JEFF STEIN,
ELIZABETH DWOSKIN,
HANNAH NATANSON
AND JONATHAN O'CONNELL

Billionaire Elon Musk's blitzkrieg on Washington has brought into focus his vision for a dramatically smaller and weaker government, as he and a coterie of aides move to control, automate — and substantially diminish — hundreds if not thousands of public functions.

In less than three weeks, Musk's U.S. DOGE Service has followed the same playbook at one federal agency after another: Install loyal-

ists in leadership. Hoover up internal data, including the sensitive and the classified. Gain control of the flow of funds. And push hard — by means legal or otherwise — to eliminate jobs and programs not ideologically aligned with Trump administration goals.

The DOGE campaign has generated chaos on a near-hourly basis across the nation's capital. But it appears carefully choreographed in service of a broader agenda to gut the civilian workforce, assert power over the vast federal bureaucracy and shrink it to levels unseen in at

SEE DOGE ON A30

The Sunday Take: Are there any restraints that can slow Trump down? A2

Trump yanks billions for biomedical research

Critics say NIH cuts will harm facilities studying cancer and heart disease

BY DAN DIAMOND,
CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON
AND LENA H. SUN

The Trump administration is cutting billions of dollars in biomedical research funding, alarming academic leaders who said it would imperil their universities and medical centers and drawing swift rebukes from Democrats who predicted dire consequences for scientific research.

The move, announced Friday night by the National Institutes of

Health, drastically cuts its funding for "indirect" costs related to research. These are the administrative requirements, facilities and other operations that many scientists say are essential but that some Republicans have claimed are superfluous.

"The United States should have the best medical research in the world," NIH said in its announcement. "It is accordingly vital to ensure that as many funds as possible go towards direct scientific research costs rather than administrative overhead."

In a social media post, NIH said the change would save more than \$4 billion a year, effective immediately. The note highlighted the multibillion-dollar endowments of Harvard University, Yale

SEE NIH ON A7

Memories of attack linger as 'Big Easy' parties on

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE

NEW ORLEANS — Five weeks after a deadly terrorist attack shattered the first hours of the new year, Bourbon Street is ready to celebrate the Super Bowl. But throughout much of the French Quarter and downtown, revelers are being greeted with some of the strictest security ever seen here: steel barricades, fortified bollards, traffic gates and perimeter checkpoints; 200 state police, 300 National Guard troops and officers from two dozen federal agencies; plus police dogs, drones and military vehicles.

Even without the horror of Jan. 1, when a driver raced down several crowded blocks of Bourbon, intentionally ramming dozens of pedestrians and killing 14, New Orleans would be taking no chances. President Donald Trump is set to attend the game. Some 200,000 visitors are expected, and about 75,000 will pack the Superdome to see the Kansas City Chiefs and Philadelphia Eagles face off.

Officials have very publicly

SEE NEW ORLEANS ON A10

On the field: Super Bowl matchup is a rematch from two years ago. D1

Something the Federal Reserve didn't bank on: A spying case

BY ANDREW ACKERMAN

When federal agents arrested John Harold Rogers late last month and charged him with a form of spying on behalf of China, a search of the former Federal Reserve economist's modest one-bedroom apartment in Vienna, Virginia, turned up \$50,000 in cash.

The substantial stash, found in his wife's closet, emerged as one of several eye-popping details in what may be a first-of-its-kind

case of a former Federal Reserve employee to be charged with a conspiracy to commit economic espionage.

Rogers, 63, had been a senior adviser to the Federal Reserve Board of Governors before he was arrested Jan. 31. He is accused of leaking confidential Fed information from at least 2018, and then lying about it to investigators. He leaked to a pair of Chinese agents posing as graduate students, the United States says.

Rogers denies the charges.

The tale of the alleged Fed-turned-spy has shocked many of Rogers's former co-workers at the buttoned-up central bank, a workplace unaccustomed to having one of their own at the center of an explosive criminal matter. (Rogers parted ways with the Fed in 2021.) In a town that loves to gossip, it's one of the wildest stories outside of Elon Musk's blitzkrieg to radically shrink federal agencies. The case has sparked more than a dozen threads on Reddit and made

waves on social media platforms.

The case appears to have emboldened Republican officials scouring for disloyalty from the halls of government and seeking to support Musk's work. Edward R. Martin Jr., a conservative activist who became the U.S. attorney for D.C. last month, highlighted the case as an example of "people who are acting against our American people in every way," in a letter to the billionaire last week.

Rogers's former colleagues at the Fed — who are far more

comfortable speaking about the direction of the economy than a criminal case — recalled Rogers as a prolific researcher who split his time between China and the United States. Most declined to speak for this story. "I would be very happy to talk to you about tariffs, the economic outlook, or Fed monetary policy," said one former official who worked with Rogers. "However, I'm not comfortable speaking to you about Rogers."

SEE FEDERAL RESERVE ON A8



FAMILY PHOTOS

FROM LEFT: Mark Shterenberg, 80, worked on optical research at NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory and lived in Pacific Palisades. Rodney Nickerson, 82, who died in the Altadena fire, was an engineer at Lockheed Martin and a church leader. Kim Winiecki, 77, had been becoming more introverted, so her friends often took her out to have fun. She died after refusing to leave what she called her sanctuary.

METRO

Some workers fight back as Trump wages war on the federal bureaucracy.

OPINION

404: Government not found. A raft of pages gone dark under Trump.



ARTS & STYLE

Anthony Mackie, a longtime sideman, finally takes up the shield.

BUSINESS

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Two new reasons to revisit Joni Mitchell's remarkable catalogue.

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